

1.2 The Internet

The Internet brings the world to your desktop, no doubt. But that world also includes a sub-world of spyware, worms, phishing attacks, and more.

The most common of online irritants is spam e-mail. Spam is simply unsolicited email that urge you to buy herbal concoctions to enlarge certain body parts, promise youthfulness via a pill, say that you've won a Rolex watch, and so on. These mails invariably contain a link to a supposed online store that will ask you for a credit card number for an online payment. It is difficult to believe how someone can fall for a trick like this, but apparently, there are a few innocent people out there who get tricked into buying a "herbal" cure or a "collector's watch." Needless to say, you need to just delete these mails.

The other common annoyance, which can also bring down your PC, is spyware / adware. The source of these is most usually pornographic sites or those with cracks for software. These sites can also be the very links you get in spam mail. Once they get installed, they are able to send a list of the Web sites you surf, and even your e-mail address. Based on your surfing habits, spam is sent to your email ID, advertising products or services that would ostensibly be of interest to you.

An adware program will open browser windows all by itself and direct you to Web sites selling products of the same nature. Some of them are so designed that if you close the window that they bring up, they will open two or more instantly!

If you receive a suspicious looking file in an e-mail (something like "annakournikova nude playing tennis.avi.scr") even from a known source, do not download the file. It is likely that a virus has hacked into the sender's e-mail client (or even disguised the sending address as something else—yes, that's possible too) and is sending out spam or offensive mails. The affected